

Optimized Content Marketing Strategy How-to Guide

The Power of 3:

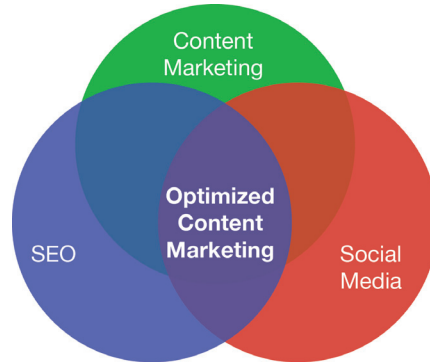
Content Marketing + SEO + Social Media



Optimized Content Marketing Strategy How-to Guide

There is a new way to outrank your competitors in Google and get found for the keywords your prospects are using to find your business. It is a proven, integrated, tactical approach we call “**The Power of 3**”:

{ Content Marketing + Search Engine Optimization (SEO) + Social Media }



The sum of these tactics is Optimized Content Marketing. When these three marketing tactics are deliberately executed together within an optimized content marketing campaign, the results are:

- 🔍 **improved and prolonged organic search rankings**
- 👁️ **increased impressions**
- 👉 **increased likelihood of clickthroughs**
- 👤 **conversions and leads**

Businesses that use this approach experience these results within two-to-four weeks of launching their optimized content marketing campaign.

An **Optimized Content Marketing Strategy** will help you outrank your competitors, but it will not happen overnight. It will take longer to execute and see results than a paid search campaign, but it differs in that it will have a longer life and further reach than a paid search campaign.

Overview

Learn how to develop an optimized content marketing strategy to outrank your competitors in Google and drive quality traffic to your business. This **Optimized Content Marketing Strategy How-To Guide** includes the following sections:

1. The Importance of SEO in the Digital Marketing Mix
2. Content Marketing versus Optimized Content Marketing
3. The Power of 3 from the Google Search Box
4. The Hierarchy of Web Presence Optimization
5. The Keyword Gap
6. An Optimized Content Marketing Strategy Case Study
7. SEO Metrics to Measure

1. The Importance of SEO in the Digital Marketing Mix

SEO has evolved drastically over the past ten years and is guaranteed to continue evolving for the next ten. Google changes its algorithm over 500 times a year! This makes the task of successfully SEOing your web presence not only incredibly challenging, but also time consuming and never ending.

Here are **6 reasons** why SEO should continue to be a **priority** in your digital marketing mix:

1. Every day there are one billion Google searches performed worldwide and that number is not decreasing. ¹
2. 100% of searchers look at the organic side of search (the left-hand side). ²
3. 85% of searchers will click on the organic side of search over paid. ³
4. The average click-through rate (CTR) for the top organic search position in Google is approximately 36%, while the CTR for the top paid search position in Google is just 2%. ⁴
5. The average CTR for organic search results on page one of Google is approximately 8%, versus only 2% CTR for paid search ads. ⁵
6. Organic search is the #1 lead conversion tactic outranking email marketing and paid search. ⁶

Why are these statistics so strong? Simple. Searchers trust the relevancy and timeliness of Google's organic search results. When we isolate Google's organic search business, at its core is the simple concept of "relevancy." Google is in the business of returning the most relevant search results to every person on this planet.

The Power of 3
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The Power of 3 is about creating, distributing and measuring optimized marketing content that is targeted to your prospects. Content that they want and find relevant. It is also about creating fresh, relevant content for Google.

1. Google, *Facts about Google and Competition*, <http://www.google.com/competition/howgooglesearchworks.html> (24 April 2012), About Search.

2. Matt McGee, "Eye-Tracking Study: Everybody Looks At Organic Listings, But Most Ignore Paid Ads On Right," *Search Engine Land*, 10 March 2011, <http://searchengineland.com/eye-tracking-study-everybody-looks-at-organic-listings-but-most-ignore-paid-ads-on-right-67698> (26 October 2011).

3. Optify, Inc., *The Changing Face of SERPs: Organic Click Through Rate*, April 2011, <http://www.optify.net/inbound-marketing-resources/new-study-how-the-new-face-of-serps-has-altered-the-ctr-curve> (21 April 2011), Resources.

4. Ibid.

5. eMarketer Inc., *Paid Search Clickthrough Rates Up Year Over Year*, 23 January 2012, <http://www.emarketer.com/Article.aspx?id=1008791&R=1008791> (24 January 2012), Articles.

6. Forbes, *2009 Forbes Advertising Effectiveness Survey*, 1 June 2009, as reported by eMarketer <http://www.emarketer.com/Article.aspx?R=1007131> (12 June 2009), Articles.

2. Content Marketing versus Optimized Content Marketing

Content marketing is not a new term or tactic. The practice of content marketing has been in use for decades. Yes, even before the Internet! According to a study by the Custom Content Council and ContentWise, online content marketing grew to nearly \$16.6 billion last year. ⁷ And according to the Content Marketing Institute, 60% of marketers plan to increase spend on content marketing over the next 12 months. ⁸

Content Marketing	Optimized Content Marketing
The Content Marketing Institute's official definition:	gShift's official definition:
"Content Marketing is the art of understanding exactly what your prospects and customers need to know. Then delivering that content to them in a relevant and compelling way to grow your business." ⁹	" Optimized Content Marketing is the art of understanding exactly what your prospects and customers need to know and deliberately producing optimized content based on keywords that are driving organic search traffic and conversions . Then delivering that optimized content in a relevant and compelling way to grow your business by socializing the content through your organization's social networks ."
Content marketing accomplishes many marketing and business objectives such as: • Knowledge and thought leadership • Customer acquisition and retention • Branding and positioning • Lead generation and sales	Optimized Content Marketing accomplishes three additional marketing and business objectives: • Get found in Google for the keywords your prospects are using to try to find you • Generate social signals • Create trusted backlinks
What are some examples of optimized content? Blogs, Press Releases, Client Case Studies, How-To Guides, White Papers, eBooks, Video	

The key to a successful optimized content marketing strategy is a consistent commitment to executing on a content schedule. This is covered in more detail in Section 6: An Optimized Content Marketing Strategy Case Study.

7. Pamela Parker, "Study: Digital Content Marketing Spend Reached Nearly \$16.6B In 2011," *Marketing Land*, 26 April 2012, <http://marketingland.com/study-digital-content-marketing-spend-reached-nearly-16-6b-in-2011-10785> (26 April 2012).

8. Joe Pulizzi, *2012 B2B Content Marketing Benchmarks, Budgets and Trends [Research Report]*, 5 December 2011, <http://www.contentmarketinginstitute.com/2011/12/2012-b2b-content-marketing-research/> (24 April 2012), Content Marketing Research.

9. Content Marketing Institute, *What is Content Marketing?*, <http://www.junta42.com/resources/what-is-content-marketing.aspx> (1 March 2012), Content Marketing Research.

3. The Power of 3 from the Google Search Box

So why is an optimized content marketing strategy key to ranking organically in Google? Over a year ago now, Google started making significant changes to its search algorithm, all of which point to the fact that you cannot go wrong with an optimized content marketing strategy. Publishing original content that people want, value and find relevant, will be rewarded by Google in the form of improved rankings.



Here is The Power of 3 in action from Google's perspective:

Social Signals

In December 2010, both Google and Bing announced that they factor **social signals** into their organic search algorithms. Why? Because according to Google, social networking is about relationships and relationships prove relevance and relevance is at the core of organic search.

Distribute your optimized content to your social networks and give your website visitors every opportunity to socialize your content including: Twitter tweets and re-tweets, Google +1's and shares, Facebook likes and shares, LinkedIn shares, YouTube views, and Pinterest likes and repins.

Panda & Penguin Updates

In February 2011, Google launched a series of updates that focused on "helping people find more high-quality sites in search." In other words, the **Panda & Penguin Updates** focus on penalizing low-quality sites and sites with spammy backlinks. So how do you get a high-quality site? According to Google, by:

- “delivering the best possible experience for users”
- “developing high-quality content rather than trying to optimize for any particular Google algorithm”

This way your site will be more likely to rank well in the long term by surviving future Google web spam updates.

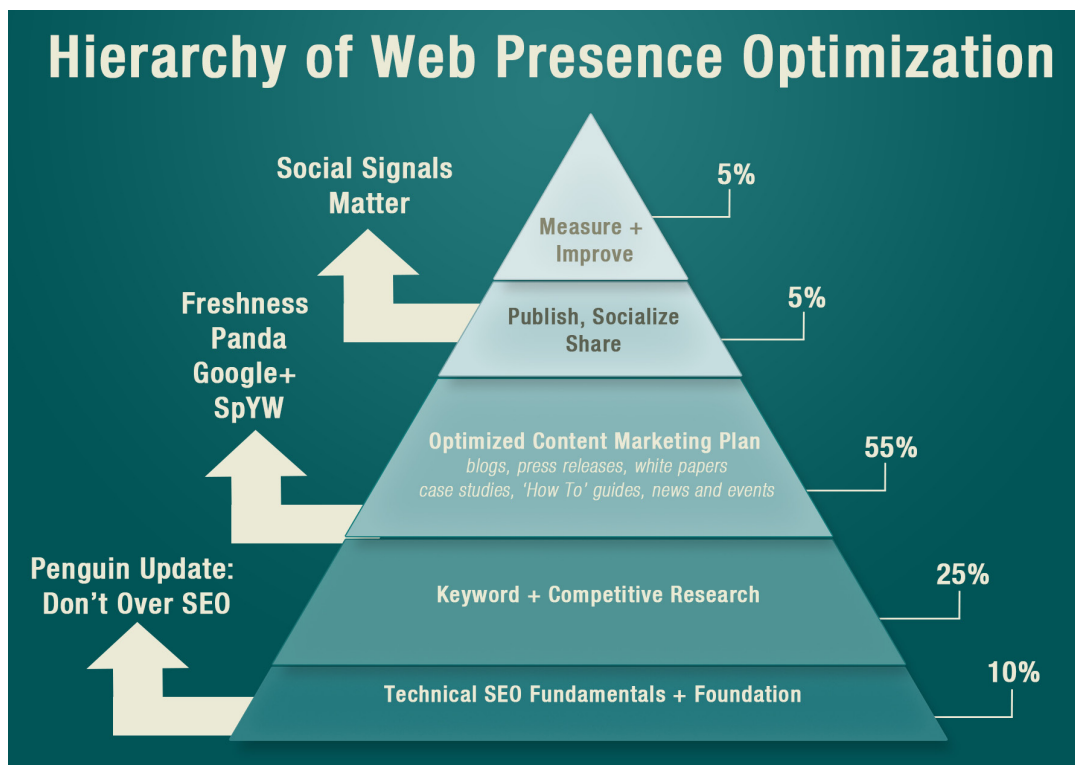
Freshness Updates

In November 2011, Google launched the **Freshness Update** that gives priority to fresh, timely content such as press releases, blogs, news and events. Why? Because fresh content is more relevant.

Give Google what it wants – fresh, relevant, timely optimized content.

4. The Hierarchy of Web Presence Optimization

To execute on the concept of The Power of 3, focus your time and effort on a proven theory called **The Hierarchy of Web Presence Optimization**. It comes from the belief that the basic fundamentals of SEO are required before success with an optimized content marketing strategy can be achieved.



Highlights

Each tier addresses a particular Google algorithm change as well as guidelines for how much time should be invested at each tier.

Review the Technical SEO Foundation & Fundamental's checklist. Note this foundational tier accounts for approximately 10% of the overall SEO effort.

Checklist: Technical SEO Fundamentals & Foundation

- ☐ Setting up robots.txt, 301 redirects, sitemap, title tags, etc.
- ☐ Configuration and cross-referencing of a blog presence and social accounts including: LinkedIn, Twitter, Facebook, YouTube, Pinterest, Google+ and any other industry-specific social media or sharing sites.
- ☐ Implementation of social sharing icons throughout the main website and blog sites.
Backlinking from respected industry and local directories.
- ☐ Setting up Google Places listings.
- ☐ Understanding web page load time and server details that may affect rankings.

The **Keyword & Competitive Research** and **Optimized Content Marketing Plan** tiers account for 80% of the overall effort! For this reason, they are the focus of the next two sections.

5. The Keyword Gap

Every organization that starts an organic search optimization process has a “keyword gap.” This is defined as the gap between the keywords you believe your organization should be found for in the search engines versus the keywords your prospects are actually using to try to find the products and services you sell.

Before you start writing content for your optimized content marketing strategy you need to close your keyword gap. This is important because keywords are at the core of every organic search strategy. Coincidentally, at the core of Google's organic search algorithm is relevance for keywords.

Be patient with this step. Careful consideration and research will pay off. It is also worth noting that this process never ends as you continue to learn how your prospects search for your business. You should and will continually refine your keyword list.



Steps to Closing your Keyword Gap:

a) Create/Tweak Your List of Keywords - Make a top 10 list of the keywords you believe you should be found for in the search engines. Include: branded and non-branded keyword phrases, long-tail keyword phrases, local keyword phrases, industry-specific keywords. (Download: [Getting Your Keywords Right](#))

b) Determine Rank and Volume - Use a keyword research tool to discover other keywords to consider, search volumes, and questions people are asking – these types of queries can be used as the basis for blog post topics. WordStream is a good example of a keyword research tool that can provide insight into alternative keywords.

c) Competitive Analysis – Consider competition in Steps #1 and #2 above. How are your competitors ranking? By looking at their websites, what keywords do you think they are trying to rank for? Keep in mind that just because your competitor is outranking you for a keyword does not mean it is the right keyword for you.

d) Understanding Keywords Driving Traffic - Perform research to determine what keywords are currently driving traffic to your website, which pages are ranking for those keywords (i.e. what pages people are arriving on), how much time they are spending on the site, and which keywords are resulting in conversions.

e) Create, Optimize & Publish Content - Limit your optimization efforts for each web page or content campaign to only one or two keyword phrases. Publish blog posts, press releases, case studies and videos to keep web content fresh and relevant to your prospects and customers and to help them find the answers they are looking for.

f) Measure Results – Use gShift Labs' **Web Presence Optimization software** to measure the results of your optimized content marketing campaign including:

- Change in rank or position for the keyword
- Number of keywords generated
- Number of visitors
- Number of conversions
- Number of backlinks generated
- Number of social signals created

6. An Optimized Content Marketing Strategy Case Study

Pratt Homes is a well-established builder of townhomes, condos and detached homes in Simcoe County, Canada. Founded in 1890, Pratt has had to evolve significantly over the past decade in terms of how they market and sell their products and services. Like most businesses, the web now plays a crucial role and “being found” online is top priority.

Prior to Pratt Homes implementing their optimized content marketing strategy they were only being found for their branded keywords, which means that their prospects had to be familiar with their brand (Pratt) in order to find them on the web. Optimally, a business wants to be found for their “un-branded keywords.”

The **Client Success Management Team** at gShift Labs applied the Hierarchy of Web Presence Optimization model to Pratt's web presence as follows:

a) Technical SEO Fundamentals & Foundation

They started by analyzing Pratt's technical SEO foundation and addressing issues with their core web presence infrastructure that would delay SEO results.

Next, they implemented the core elements required to support an optimized content marketing strategy and improve SEO rankings, including:

- Strengthening the main website to ensure it is being fully crawled and indexed by Google.
- Setting up all relevant social media sites (Twitter, Facebook, LinkedIn, YouTube) and cross-linking with all web presence points where applicable.
- Setting up a local search presence.
- Building out strong, keyword-rich backlinks in business-relevant directories.



b) Keyword Research

Pratt's challenge to close their **keyword gap** was not unlike most other organizations that embrace and delve into the world of SEO and web presence optimization. Not only were conversion rates on organic search traffic unknown, the only search terms driving traffic to the site were branded terms (Pratt Homes and Pratt Homes Barrie). This meant that Pratt's target market (new home buyers) had to already know about their brand when performing a search.

The million-dollar question was, what unbranded search terms were prospects using and which would drive the highest conversion rate for Pratt Homes?

gShift's Client Success Management team performed some initial keyword and competitive research, and then set four goals with Pratt's marketing team:

- 1. Dominate, in a controlled way, page one in Google (all top 10 positions) for the main brand Pratt.**
- 2. Determine and agree on the top two unbranded keywords to focus on.**
- 3. Be found on page one in Google for the top two agreed upon unbranded keyword phrases.**
- 4. Continually expand on unbranded keywords to optimize for as Pratt's web presence is improved.**

Additional keyword and competitive research revealed that "Condos Barrie" and "New Homes Barrie" were the top two unbranded keyword phrases Pratt should focus on for Goal #2 above.

c) Optimized Content Marketing Plan

Once the technical foundation and keyword research was complete, it was time to execute on the optimized content marketing plan – that is, deliberately giving Pratt prospects and Google what they want – fresh, relevant, optimized content (for keywords that are driving traffic) on a consistent basis in the form of website content, press releases, blog posts, case studies and white papers.

Pratt's optimized content was not only rich with keywords, but also backlinks. Blog posts, press releases and case studies were optimized for their keyword phrases, while maintaining a natural flow without over optimizing. Particular attention was given to the following:

- Title tags, URLs, and anchor text in backlinks containing the most important keywords
- Placement and frequency of the keywords in the initial paragraphs
- Social icons on web pages

d) Publish, Socialize & Share Content

gShift's Client Success Management team created a **content schedule** that matched Pratt's budget. An excerpt of it is shown below:

	Keywords	Type	Creator/Writer	Distributed
Q1	Pratt Homes Barrie, New homes Barrie	On Site Web Pages, Press Release, Blog Post	gShift Labs	Social Networks, PRWeb, Blog Directories, Email Marketing List, Local Press
Q2	Pratt Homes Barrie Condos Barrie	On Site Web Pages, Press Release, 2 Blog Posts, Case Studies	gShift Labs	Social Networks, PRWeb, Blog Directories, Email Marketing List, Local Press

Example publishing schedule for “Condos Barrie”:

1. Press release optimized for Condos Barrie, distributed via PRWeb to over 5,000 media outlets as well as to local media outlets. It received over 64,000 impressions, 717 reads, and 115 interactions on PRWeb alone.
2. Blog post optimized for Condos Barrie, and distributed via email marketing.
3. Both press release and blog post link back to website. Backlinks contain the anchor text Condos Barrie.
4. Website optimized for Condos Barrie.
5. Social icons included on all web pages (press release, blog post).
6. All content socialized through Twitter, Facebook, LinkedIn, YouTube, and Google+ for Business.

e) Measure & Improve

Six months later, how is Pratt Homes' web presence performing? When we revisit their goals set out above, we find that:

1. They are now occupying 8 of the top 10 positions on page one in Google compared to just 3 when they first began their SEO efforts.
2. They are now consistently on page one for “Condos Barrie” and “New Homes Barrie”
- when they started they were beyond page two.



3. Their web presence has expanded from 60 web pages indexed in Google to 120.
4. Total traffic to their website has increased from 2,400 visitors/month to over 5,400 visitors/month.
5. They have amassed 150 Facebook Fans and 270 Twitter Followers, the majority of whom are local.

7. SEO Metrics to Measure

The following eight SEO metrics are useful for tracking the progress of a web presence in organic search. Each metric provides signals as to what is working and what is not so your optimized content marketing strategy can be constantly tweaked and results improved.

Rankings/Position: Track your organic search rankings for the keyword phrases your organization wants to be found for in the search engine results. Follow your SEO ranking metric regularly to understand if your organization is expanding its web presence.

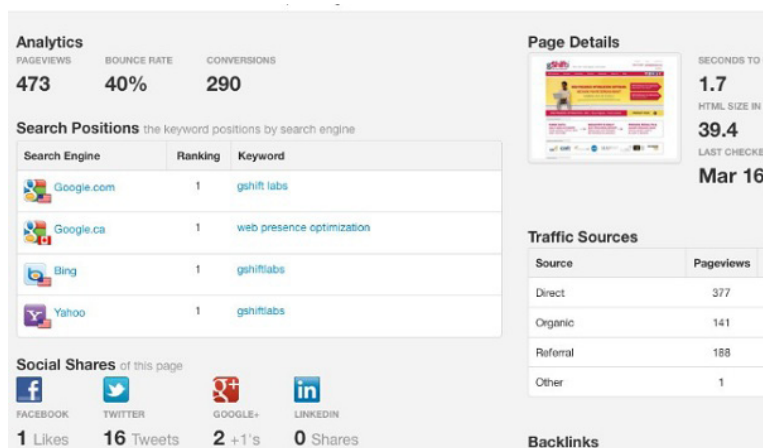
Keywords Driving Traffic: Which web pages are ranking high for the keywords driving traffic to your website, and how much time are they spending on the site? What unique keywords are being used to find your organization? Which keywords have a high bounce rate (only visiting one web page)?

Backlinks: Backlinks should naturally increase as you build out your optimized content marketing strategy of blog posts, press releases and case studies. The associated anchor text as well as the domain authority of the websites linking to your content affect the quality of your backlinks.

Indexed Pages: The more pages indexed in Google, the more opportunity you have to be found. As you build out your optimized content marketing strategy adding new blog posts, web pages and press releases on a regular basis, your index count will grow.

Social Signals: Track the number of backlinks from social media sites – comments, likes, shares, tweets, +1s, pins – to all your web content including web pages, blog posts, white papers, press releases, case studies, videos, etc.

SEO Metrics in gShift Labs



Website Traffic: Is your organic and referral traffic increasing? Or are most of your visitors direct traffic? Which traffic converts better – organic, referral, direct or social? Tracking these website traffic metrics can help you understand both your SEO and optimized content marketing strategies.

Organic Conversions/Goals: What percentage of your organic search traffic takes action on your website? Which keywords are driving the most conversions? Are your conversions increasing based on your optimized content marketing strategy?

Competitive Data: How do your competitors rank for keyword phrases that matter to you? What are your competitors' top ranking keyword phrases? How many backlinks do they have compared to you? How many pages are being indexed? How often are they crawled by the search engines?

Conclusion

While the fundamentals of organic search optimization remain important – such as ensuring you have a strong technical website that the search engine robots can crawl, and addressing local search and industry-specific directories for backlinking purposes – a real shift is taking place in the ongoing approach to traditional SEO. That shift is the creation, publishing and distribution of an optimized content marketing strategy.

Success in organic search and social media is only possible with an optimized content marketing strategy. If you don't have the latter, you may as well forget about being remotely successful with the former. Focus on strong, consistent and optimized content distributed effectively through the social networks and you will crush your competitors in organic search over the long term. Plus you will likely never be penalized by Google.



About gShift Labs

gShift Labs' industry leading, patent-pending software system, Web Presence Optimizer™, is helping marketers and agencies across North America and globally track, monitor, measure and report on an entire web presence for improved SEO results. Founded in 2009, gShift Labs is changing the way people think about and perform organic search optimization. gShift believes that companies should have control over their SEO campaigns just like they have control over email marketing and paid search. Hundreds of companies use gShift's SEO software system.

For more information, please contact us at 1-866-743-5960 or sales@gShiftLabs.com.